former ministers of state and six former chief ministers. The newly formed BJP claimed that it was the ‘real’ Janata Party, not a breakaway faction.[5]

When Janata Party leader Chandra Shekhar challenged the BJP’s inheritance claim, arguing that the remaining rump was actually the ‘real’ Janata, the ECI initially seemed to disagree. It gave the BJP ‘national party status’ and froze the Janata Party’s election symbol for a few months (which meant that Chandra Shekhar’s Janata Party could not contest elections on it) until the Commission could take a final call.[6]

As Advani told his party’s newest delegates in Gujarat, the RSS question had been so central in this break-up that, until this dispute, the Janata Party had never taken a single decision by vote. The only time it would do so was to ‘oust’ the Jan Sangh members. ‘This step by the Janata Party proved a blessing in disguise,’ he said, ‘not only for us but also for Indian politics itself.’[7]

The BJP’s umbilical-cord attachment to the RSS and the exact nature of the relationship between the two has been a central question from the party’s very foundational moment. In fact, its first few weeks in this new avatar perfectly encapsulated the old tensions around the RSS–Jan Sangh relationship as well.[8]

In its inaugural convention in New Delhi on 5–6 April 1980, the BJP tried to downplay talk of the RSS link. The visual backdrop on the stage at this session was different from the martial-Hindu-heroes imagery of Chhatrapati Shivaji and Maharana Pratap on display at the Jan Sangh’s founding ceremony twenty-nine years earlier. Instead, the backdrop now displayed images of Mahatma Gandhi; Jayaprakash Narayan, the Gandhian socialist icon whose call for ‘total revolution’ against Indira Gandhi in the 1970s had galvanised the united anti-Congress Opposition front during the Emergency; and the Sangh’s late idealogue Deendayal Upadhyaya.[9] Seeking to appropriate the legacy of the Janata Party, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, the BJP’s first president,[10] declared at the convention that the new party would fight the upcoming elections on the basis of the ‘1977 election manifesto of the Janata Party because there was nothing wrong in the Janata Party’s policies and programmes’.[11] Advani too